

“In Christ”
For The Praise of His Glory

An Exegetical Paper

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INTRODUCTION

An essential question arises in every human being, regardless of race, religion, or culture. This question has baffled philosophers and thinkers. A question that every Human being is compelled to ask and try to answer. What is the purpose of life? What is a human being? And

Once the first question is answered, as every religion and philosophy does, the question then shifts from a foundational “why” to a practical “how.” How can someone accomplish their purpose? What is the plan to achieve it, and how does an individual’s life fit into that plan? In Christian terms, it is shown as the heavily coveted “calling.

The focus of this paper is to show that the church is built upon *the work of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit*, contained “in Christ” to **The Praise of His Glory**. To do so, it will explore Ephesians 1:1-14 to show how Paul answers these questions by pointing to God's purpose for all things, and how in their perfect condition, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit collaborate in unity to fulfill that purpose and give the foundation for the church “In Christ”.

CONTEXT

Letter to the Ephesians

A letter written by Paul while in prison in Rome (Acts 28:16), probably around 60 AD, aims to lay the foundations for the church. In this paper, the word church is not used as a specific congregation but rather implies the saints, both Jew and Gentile, comprising the different communities and the global body of Christ. Some of the oldest texts do not contain the phrase “in Ephesus,” as it was intended to be a circular letter circulated among the churches in the region¹. It was not a reactive letter, such as Paul would predominantly write; instead, it clarifies a message to

¹Craig S. Keener *The IVP Bible Background Commentary: New Testament Second Edition* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press, 2014), 542.

the church that began predominantly Jewish and is now becoming predominantly Gentile, reminding them of the Jewish apocalyptic framework of this era, the coming era, and the role of the church in this reality.

As such, it establishes the basis for what the church is built upon (theology), what the church is and does (missiology), and how the church functions (practical). This three-fold idea gives the main structure to the letter: Ephesians 1 and 2 focus primarily on building the church upon Who God is, what He did, why He did it, and what He has purposed for the church. Ephesians 3 and 4 transition into how the church impacts the building up of the church and pushes its mission forward. Finally, Ephesians 5 and 6 show how this reality and this mission affect our daily lives.

CONTENT

Salutation: ἐν Χριστός (“In Christ”)

The letter is addressed to the saints, whom it describes as those faithful “In Christ.” The use of the preposition ἐν within the phrase “in Christ” should stop the reader as an apparent grammatical incoherence. It should be expected to find a preposition that denotes the object of faith, such as “to” in any of its Greek variants. Instead, Paul uses ἐν, a preposition that denotes the position of the faithful rather than an object of faith.² By doing so, Paul is defining the faithful, the church, as those contained, inside of, positioned in, belonging within, clothed by, “in Christ”.

In the next thirteen verses, Paul uses the same phrase with a slight variation a total of eleven times. For this reason, it is within this salutation that Paul provides the key to understanding the letter of Ephesians, specifically, the theology that lays the foundation of the church. As Keathley

² James Strong In *A Concise Dictionary of the Words in the Greek Testament and The Hebrew Bible* (1:28. Bellingham, WA: Logos Bible Software, 2009.), vol. 1:9.

notes, “Paul’s repeated use of the term reveals that it is the central key to the apostle’s doctrine of salvation and perhaps even his whole theology.” Just like one hops into an ark, Paul describes salvation as being “in Christ,” placing Jesus as the container of the Church destined for salvation.

Union with Christ is the core truth of salvation that can be seen either as encompassing all of salvation or as the center to which all components of salvation are connected.³

The primary identity of the church is a position “in Christ” and not a function, it is a gift and not an achievement, it is a union with Christ in every aspect. Life. Elected “in Christ”, participants of His life, death, and resurrection “in Christ,” partakers of every blessing “in Christ, and destined for eternal life “in Christ. Paul states that “in Adam all die, even so in Christ all shall be made alive” (1 Cor 15:22).⁴

The Blessing of The Father, The Son, and The Holy Spirit “in Christ”

The next eleven verses are a single sentence in the Greek original recited as a Jewish blessing.⁵ Having stressed the Church’s union “in Christ”, Paul uses this blessing to show the church is built for **The Praise of His Glory** upon *the work of the three Persons of the Trinity*⁶. The adoption from the Father, the redemption from the Son, and the seal from the Holy Spirit are presented by Paul both as a doxology (**The Praise of His Glory**) and as the basic identity of the

3 Kenneth Keathley, “The Work of God: Salvation,” in *A Theology for the Church* (Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2014), 544.

4 Ibid., 543

5 David H. Stern *Jewish New Testament Commentary: A Companion Volume to the Jewish New Testament*. Electronic ed. (Clarksville: Jewish New Testament Publications, 1996),

6 Harold W. Hoehner “Ephesians.” In *The Bible Knowledge Commentary: An Exposition of the Scriptures*, edited by J. F. Walvoord and R. B. Zuck (Wheaton, IL: Victor Books, 1985), vol 2: 617

faithful saints “In Christ” ⁷. Meaning that each person of the Trinity gives **Praise to The Glory of God** (doxology) through an action that builds the church.

The doxology of the Father Ephesians 1:3-6

The first section of the benediction is the doxology offered from the Father to the God-head through the adoption of the church. Now that the church is “In Christ,” it has received every blessing in the heavenly places. While it does benefit the church, the main purpose of *the work of the Father* is **The Praise of His Glory**.

The Father’s maximum offering of **Praise for His glory** is accomplished by (1) blessing the church “in Christ”, (2) choosing the church “in Christ” before the foundation of the world to be holy, and (3) pre-destining it to adoption through Christ as His children. For simplicity's sake, *the work of the Father* can be summarized as the adoption of the church “in Christ”.

Paul reinforces the concept of being “in Christ” as the container of the blessings received from the Father. In Him, the church is chosen, predestined, and elected for love and adoption. To explain the concept, Paul takes the reader back to the beginning. Even before creation, the Father loved the church, but He did it through Christ and “in Christ” alone. The container is predestined, so the saints receive their predestination only when in the container itself. Akin notes “Paul supplies the answer: we were elected in Christ Jesus. God elected his own Son, who is our representative, and we find our election in him.”⁸

⁷ Robert Jamieson, A. R. Fausset, and David Brown *Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible* (Oak Harbor, WA: Logos Research Systems, Inc., 1997) vol. 2:341

⁸ Kenneth, 545

The saints can benefit from the doxology of the Father, knowing that their true identity is as sons, not by any accomplishment, but by the goodness and love of the Father. He loved by His own choice. He did not need to do it, yet He still did it. The plan was established before the creation of the world. He decided beforehand to adopt the saints “in Christ”. Knowing what would have to happen the Father devised the perfect plan through Christ and in Christ. Kesner explains how the church's identity is changed and now both Israel and the Church are children of God. “People remained with their cultural identity, but through *the work of Messiah*, their legal status has changed to become the spiritual children of God.”⁹

The work of the Father is the adoption of the saints **for the Praise of His Glory**.

The doxology of the Son Ephesians 1:7-12

The second section of the benediction is the doxology offered from the Son to the Godhead through the redemption of the church. As noted earlier, the adoption is not only “in Christ” but also through Christ. As such, *the work of the Son* makes the adoption possible by redeeming the saints through the removal of their trespasses by His blood. It is worth noting again that while the saints do benefit, the main purpose of *the work of the Son* is **the praise of His glory**.

The Son’s maximum offering of **Praise for His glory** is accomplished by (1) redemption “in Christ” through His blood, (2) giving of His Grace in abundance as an inheritance “in Christ”, and (3) the revealing of the mystery of His will “in Christ”. For simplicity's sake, *the work of the Son* can be summarized as the redemption of the church “in Christ” and through Christ.

⁹Barney Kasdan *A Messianic Commentary: Rabbi Paul Enlightens the Ephesians on Walking with Messiah Yeshua*. Edited by Barry Rubin (Clarksville, MD: Lederer Books: A division of Messianic Jewish Publishers, 2015), 10

In this section, Paul explains how the plan devised beforehand is carried out through Christ for the redemption of the saints. Meaning, the deliverance from bondage of sin and the acquisition of the saints for eternal inheritance “in Christ”.¹⁰ While doing so, the Son revealed the eternal plan devised, according to Hoehner, “not out of but according to (*kata*) the wealth of His grace.”¹¹ The unveiling of this plan is indeed the unveiling of the Son as The Christ and as such it is the eternal “plan (**ōikōnōmia**)”¹² of the fullness of times is to bring all things together in the Messiah—both things in heaven and things on earth, all in Him.” (Eph 1:10)

Once more, Paul takes the reader back to the beginning. In Adam, the task given to humankind to (**ōikōnōmia**) steward and rule the land and everything in it, is corrupted. However, God beforehand had predestined that “in Christ” all things would be united for a good (**ōikōnōmia**) stewardship in the fullness of time.

The saints can benefit from the doxology of the Son by knowing they have been redeemed, bought by the precious blood of Christ for an eternal inheritance.¹³ But also by understanding the eternal plan to put everything under the feet of Christ for a correct rulership and as such surrendering today everything to Him.

The work of the Son is the redemption of the saints **for the Praise of His Glory**.

The Doxology of The Holy Spirit Ephesians 1:13-14

¹⁰ Harold W., vol. 2:617–18

¹¹ Ibid., vol. 2:618. Wheaton, IL: Victor Books.

¹² Strong vol. 1:51

¹³ Harold W., vol. 2:618.

The third section of the benediction is the doxology offered from the Holy Spirit to the Godhead by sealing the church “in Christ,” given that the saints are adopted by the Father and redeemed by the Son for an inheritance. The Holy Spirit then “seals” the promise as a down payment of what is to come. Once more, while the saints benefit, the main purpose of *the work of the Holy Spirit* is **the praise of His glory**.

The Holy Spirit’s maximum offering of **Praise for His glory** is accomplished by (1) sealing the saints “in Christ” (2) as a guarantee of the inheritance to come (3) while still waiting for its fulfillment. For simplicity’s sake, *the work of the Holy Spirit* can be summarized as the sealing of the church “in Christ”.

By being united to Christ and redeemed through Christ, the plan of adoption is fulfilled, but not yet fully received. The good news is that by hearing and believing that God saves through Christ, the saints are adopted and then sealed. Harold Heohner demonstrates that it is once more *the work of the trinity* exalting the Godhead: “God is the One who seals, Christ is the sphere in which the **seal** is done, and the Holy Spirit is the instrument of the seal.”¹⁴

It should be noted that this seal is a double-fold blessing. The word used by Paul, **sphragizō**¹⁵, implies complete ownership and security carried by the owner. According to Keener: “A wax seal would have a mark of ownership or identification stamped in it, identifying who was

14 Hoehner, Harold W. 1985. “Ephesians.” In *The Bible Knowledge Commentary: An Exposition of the Scriptures*, edited by J. F. Walvoord and R. B. Zuck, 2:619. Wheaton, IL: Victor Books.

15 James, vol. 1:70

attesting what was inside the container that had been sealed.”¹⁶ The first blessing is the identification of the saints as belonging to God “in Christ.”

The second blessing can be discovered by the word **Arrhābon**, or guarantee. In the seal of the Holy Spirit, the saints have received a guarantee of the inheritance to come. However, this is a “term used in ancient business documents to mean a ‘down payment.’” It is, in itself, a bond, a sum of money, a large part of the payment, given in advance as a guarantee that the full amount will be paid later. This means that the saints, through the Holy Spirit, can live a life that testifies to themselves of the life to come in the age to come.

The work of the Holy Spirit is the seal of the saints **for the Praise of His Glory**.

APPLICATION

The letter to the Ephesians is foundational for the church; as such, it should be considered in every sphere of Christian life. It is not a reactionary letter and is not to be taken to “solve” problems within the church or the believer. As such, every pastor and counselor should always take it as a solid foundation to ground the believer and the church so that they may grow into maturity and conformity to Christ. This should be done by grounding the believer in the identity provided by God “in Christ” and the purpose of all creation to **Praise the Glory of God**. By doing so, the pastor and counselor can help ensure that every aspect of the believer’s life is rightly oriented and plays a role within this era while creation waits for the fullness of time.

When confronting every life decision, the counselor and pastor should guide the believer to examine the doxology of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit and ask: If the maximum work of God was done not for the benefit of the saints but for the praise of His Glory, then what should the

16 Craig S., 544

purpose of the saint be? The answer is clear and straightforward: The saints are to be **for the Praise of His Glory**. This means that every decision should be passed through a filter: How is this action praising the glory of God? How does this action exhibit God's attributes to exalt Him?

These questions could push the saints to live a life based on works. However, when analyzing *the work of the Trinity*, it should be noted that the only way to give all the praise to His glory is by living in the identity already provided "in Christ," to rest on who He says the saints are and not on how the saints might perceive themselves. Thus, the *work of the saints* is to rest "in Christ" and represent Christ by living out their identity. Sons of God adopted by the Father, redeemed through the Son, and sealed by the Holy Spirit "in Christ."

In every moment of doubt, disillusionment, depression, or anxiety, the saint can look back at Ephesians to be built up again in the certainty that they have been chosen, predestined, loved, sealed, bought, forgiven, and guaranteed for the age to come. At the same time, look at the "down-payment" given by the Holy Spirit as the first fruits of their own resurrection, as to live a life taking hold of eternal life.

Finally, with a deep understanding of the great mystery revealed, the church should strive to live in the present age under the authority of the king to come: the Christ in whom all things will be united in the fullness of time. Thus, the church should live a life of simple obedience to the one who blessed us for The Praise of His Glory.

CONCLUSION

As *Kenneth Keathley* highlights: "Clearly, 'in Christ' is not an empty phrase, a throwaway line, or a space-filler expression to the apostle. His repetition is not a mantra. Paul's repeated use of the term reveals that it is the central key to the apostle's doctrine of salvation and perhaps even his

whole theology.”¹⁷ Understanding the meaning of being united with Christ, being one with Christ, and being contained in Christ should be the foundation of Christian life. It should be the lens through which Pauline theology and even Johannine theology are read. Doing so would not only solve eternal debates about predestination, but it would also trust the believer to live a life based on an identity given as a gift and prepared beforehand.

It is “in Christ” that the saints are saved, predestined, loved, redeemed, sealed, contained, prepared, preserved, justified, empowered, covered, and blessed. As John Murray explains, “Union with Christ is a very inclusive subject. It embraces the wide span of salvation from its ultimate source in the eternal election of God to its final fruition in the glorification of the elect... Union with Christ binds all together...”¹⁸

It is “in Christ” that the church can be built up. It is “in Christ” that the church can thrive. It is “in Christ” and “in Christ” alone that the saints and the church can live a life that fully gives **all the Praise to His glory.**

The church has been chosen beforehand for adoption, redemption, and sealing “in Christ” for an age to come in which Christ will steward the heavens and the earth. All was done not by the Trinity for the Praise of His Glory. May the lives of every member of the church and *the work of the saints* rest always in Christ and be for **The Praise Of His Glory.**

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